active. Although in a few cases the army conceded to ceasefire groups registering political parties, absent of electoral politics and without any commitment to comprehensive strategies for lasting peace, the ceasefires were concerned only with bringing a halt to violence, at least for a time, without addressing the political causes of conflict (see Farrelly 2012, p. 53, 2014, pp. 308-312; Laoutides and Ware 2016; South 2009, pp. 120-121).

Today, things are quite different. Rather than the army negotiating directly with its enemies, from 2012 the government's peace technical team has played an intermediary role. Su Mon Thazin Aung (2016) describes the team as operating at the centre of a "peace policy community" because its functions have not been merely technical. The team has offered support to the presidency on a range of important policies with either direct or indirect consequences for the peace process. Adopting a cautious, piecemeal approach, the team has obtained formally binding commitments from parties where possible, as in the bringing of federalism to the negotiating table; and, informal commitments where necessary to keep things moving, such as by having government officials agree to turn a blind eye to the terms of the Unlawful Associations Act so as to allow armed groups declared as unlawful nevertheless to meet and discuss terms for a nationwide ceasefire.

In other words, the team's role in the peace policy community seems to have been to encourage a kind of embryonic politics. Its efforts do not, in Su Mon Thazin Aung's telling, realize politics anew, but they do at least aspire to do so, insofar as the team was concerned with the establishment of new practices, discourses and institutions than what had hitherto existed. Its activities invite the possibility of the political, inasmuch as it was concerned, up to the end of 2015, at least, with setting terms and conditions that would get collective rivals to the table on more or less equal terms, and have them express their disagreements verbally rather than through use of arms.

Similar ideas and practices animated the inaugural Naypyitaw legislature, from 2011-2016 (Chit Win 2016). The legislature, which even after the election of some NLD members still overwhelmingly comprised of army officers, former army officers and their appointees, attracted interest for being more assertive than many people had expected (as discussed in Kean 2014; Fink 2015). But rather than embrace conflict, the legislature was in its first five years concerned with managing and containing it, adopting methods aimed at obtaining consensus through restrictions on certain debates and control of antagonistic members. Its record was mixed,